

INCEPT DATE

A Blade Runner Side Story

CHARACTERS: GAFF, RICK DECKARD, BRYANT, RACHAEL, RUIZ, HAN

FADE IN:

EXT. ROOFTOP, NIGHT, RAIN

Los Angeles below, an ocean of light drowned in smog and neon. Rain in sheets. A spinner descends and lands hard on the rooftop's edge, engine cycling down.

GAFF steps out, collar up, unreadable as always. He crosses to where RICK DECKARD sits against a low wall, soaked through, not moving. Nearby, ROY BATTY's body, still, rain running off it like it runs off everything else up here, no more or less than the gravel or the pipes.

Gaff stands over the body a moment. Doesn't crouch. Doesn't touch it yet. Just looks, the way a man looks at a math problem he already knows the answer to but has to write out anyway for the file.

GAFF

You look like a man who used up a week's luck in one night.

Deckard doesn't answer right away.

DECKARD

He could've let me fall.

GAFF

Yeah.

DECKARD

Why didn't he.

GAFF

(finally crouching by the body, businesslike)

Ask him. Oh. Right.

He checks Batty's eyes, wrist, the small telltale signs a Blade Runner learns to read without thinking. Writes something on a small pad, waterproof, official.

GAFF (CONT'D)

Four for four. Bryant's going to want that in ink before morning.

DECKARD

Is that what tonight was. A count.

GAFF

(standing)

Tonight was a shift. Tomorrow it's a count. That's how the paperwork survives, even when nothing else does.

He looks toward the stairwell, then back at Deckard, something almost gentle underneath the flatness.

GAFF (CONT'D)

Go home, Deckard. You did the department's job. Whatever's left over is yours to carry, not theirs.

He turns and walks back toward the spinner without waiting for a response, already folding something small and pale between his fingers, out of habit more than intention.

INT. SEBASTIAN'S APARTMENT BUILDING, HALLWAY AND ROOMS, NIGHT

Water damage everywhere, ceilings sagging, the slow rot of a building nobody has properly lived in for decades except the one tenant who liked the company of things other people threw away. Gaff moves through it with a flashlight, stepping over a broken toy soldier the size of a small child, past a chessboard mid-game, no one left to finish it.

He finds the room where Pris died. Chalk outline already down, a junior officer's careless work, uneven at the corners. Gaff crouches, studies the room rather than the outline. Feathers from a torn pillow. A child's music box, wound down.

A second officer, unnamed, pokes his head in.

OFFICER

Tenant's not here. Sebastian, the genetic designer. Building's registered to him, but no one's seen him since the report came in.

GAFF

He built toys for a living and kept company with people the rest of the city wanted dead. My guess is he's not turning up in a hurry, and if he does, it won't be here.

OFFICER

You think he helped them.

GAFF

I think he was lonely, and they were the first thing in years that looked back at him like he mattered. That's not a crime we've got a form for.

He stands, looks once more around the wrecked, childlike room, the chessboard, the dolls, evidence of someone trying very hard to build a life out of pieces nobody else wanted.

GAFF (CONT'D)

(quiet)

Funny thing to notice. Man spends his whole career building things that look like people. Ends up trusting the ones that actually were, more than the ones who were born that way.

He clicks off the flashlight.

GAFF (CONT'D)

Log it as unresolved. Sebastian's not a suspect. He's just another name that doesn't have a closing entry yet.

He leaves the chessboard exactly as he found it, mid-game, and pulls the door shut behind him.

INT. LAPD PRECINCT, RECORDS OFFICE, NIGHT

Fluorescent light, humming too loud in the empty hours. Gaff at a terminal, entering data. RUIZ, a records officer working the graveyard shift, half-watches from another desk, bored, chewing something.

RUIZ

Four retirements in one report. Bryant's going to frame it.

GAFF

Bryant frames the arrest numbers. The names don't make it to the wall.

RUIZ

Names. Since when do we log names on these. Model designation and serial's enough for the file.

GAFF

(not looking up)

Humor me.

He types: LEON KOWALSKI. ZHORA SALOME. PRIS STRATTON. ROY BATTY. Pauses on the last one longer than the others before moving on.

RUIZ

Kowalski wasn't even Deckard's. Word is the Tyrell girl took that one.

GAFF

Rachael.

RUIZ

Whatever her name is. Funny, isn't it. A skin job doing our job for us.

GAFF

(flat, not looking up)

Careful with the word "our," Ruiz. You've never retired anything in your life. You process forms.

Ruiz shuts up, goes back to his terminal. Gaff finishes the entry, stares at the screen a moment, at Rachael's name sitting in the middle of a report about the dead, herself very much not filed as dead, not filed as anything conclusive at all.

GAFF (CONT'D)

(quiet, to himself)

No closing entry for you yet. Wonder who decides when to write one.

INT. LAPD PRECINCT, BRYANT'S OFFICE, DAY

BRYANT behind his desk, cigarette smoke curling toward a ceiling fan that barely moves it. Gaff stands across from him, report in hand.

BRYANT

Four confirmed. Clean file. Good work getting it wrapped before the brass starts asking why it took this long.

GAFF

There's an open item.

BRYANT

There's always an open item with you, Gaff. What is it this time.

GAFF

The Tyrell replicant. Rachael. She's not on the original list of six. Tyrell built her outside the standard batch, no fixed incept window that anyone's confirmed. If she's not scheduled to expire, she's not a case that closes. She's a case that just keeps existing.

BRYANT

(waving smoke away, uninterested)

Then she's not our problem. She's Tyrell's problem. And Tyrell's not in a position to have problems anymore, is he.

GAFF

Deckard's with her.

Bryant looks up properly now, something sharpening behind the boredom.

BRYANT

Is he.

GAFF

I'm telling you because you'd find out anyway, and I'd rather you hear it from someone who isn't going to dress it up.

BRYANT

And what do you want me to do with that, Gaff. Send another runner after my best runner?

GAFF

I want you to decide what she is before you decide what to do about her. Most people don't get that order reversed. She might be the only one of us who does.

BRYANT

(cold, final)

She's a product with a serial number that ran off with a state employee. Write it up as absent without report and file it under low priority. That's the department's official position, and it's about to be yours.

GAFF

(a long beat, then, quiet)

Understood.

He turns to leave.

BRYANT

Gaff.

Gaff stops.

BRYANT (CONT'D)

Don't go looking for the parts of this job that aren't there. It's not built to hold that kind of weight. Neither are you.

GAFF

(not turning around)

No. It isn't. I keep doing the math anyway.

He leaves.

INT. TYRELL CORPORATION, RECORDS ARCHIVE, DAY

Vast, cold, half the height of the building given over to files that hum quietly in climate-controlled dark. HAN, a mid-level records technician, walks Gaff between towering banks of storage.

HAN

Officially I'm not supposed to open individual subject files without a court order.

GAFF

Officially the subject's missing and presumed dangerous. That buys me a look.

HAN

(pulling up a file, uneasy)

Rachael. Nexus-6 chassis, experimental memory architecture, no scheduled decommission protocol. That's not standard. That's Tyrell testing something on his own niece, more or less. Family project.

GAFF

No incept date.

HAN

There's a date. It's just not real. Someone entered a placeholder years back and nobody ever corrected it, because nobody expected her to outlive the test.

Gaff studies the blank field on the screen where a countdown should be, where every other replicant on record has one, small, exact, inevitable.

GAFF

So she could go on same as anybody. No clock running under the floor.

HAN

Theoretically. Practically, nobody's ever tested "theoretically" against forty years of aging. Might turn out no different than anybody else running down slow. Might not.

GAFF

(quiet)

That's the whole trick of being alive, isn't it. Not knowing which one it'll be.

HAN

(uneasy at the direction this has gone)

You want me to flag the file for retirement priority or not, detective?

A long pause. Gaff looks at the blank countdown field a moment longer.

GAFF

No. Close it. Mark it inconclusive, pending further data. That's true enough to survive an audit.

HAN

(surprised)

That'll sit open forever.

GAFF

Some things should.

He turns and walks out past the towering files, small and quiet in that enormous cold archive of manufactured lives, each one carrying its number, its date, its ending, already decided by someone who never has to watch it happen.

INT. DECKARD'S APARTMENT, NIGHT

Dark, empty, the particular stillness of a place left in a hurry but not in panic. Gaff moves through it alone, flashlight off, city light through the windows enough to see by. A chair overturned and righted again out of habit rather than urgency. A window left unlatched.

He finds, on the low table by the piano, a small paper shape. Folded with care, the same hands that folded a hundred others just like it across a hundred crime scenes, except this one wasn't left as a taunt or a signature. This one was left on purpose, for him, and only him, to find.

He picks it up, turns it in the low light. Doesn't smile. Doesn't need to.

GAFF

(quiet, to the empty room)

So you knew I'd come looking. Good. Saves us both a longer conversation.

He sets the small shape back down exactly where it was, doesn't pocket it, doesn't photograph it, doesn't note it anywhere that will end up on Bryant's desk in the morning.

GAFF (CONT'D)

No incept date. No closing entry. Some files don't need one; some people decide that for themselves before the department gets the chance.

He crosses to the window, looks out at the enormous, indifferent city, its lights running on into the smog with no clear edge where the light ends and the dark begins.

GAFF (CONT'D)

(almost to himself)

Everybody's running on a number they didn't choose. Some of us just get to pretend we're not.

